

Scholasticism and dogma



The Catholic Church wielded considerable social and political power in medieval Europe, and also controlled access to learning. Education was provided by the Church and necessarily followed Christian doctrine, while libraries and universities were funded by the Church and staffed by monastic orders. Monks preserved and translated many ancient texts, mostly of Greek philosophy and latterly acquired from Islamic scholars. Scholasticism was a method of tuition that used rigorous dialectical reasoning both to teach Christian theology and to scrutinize these texts. Clerics and academics used methods of reasoning developed by Plato and

Aristotle to assess the compatibility of ideas with Christian doctrine. The theories of philosophers including Augustine and Thomas Aquinas were also examined, and either adopted to defend Christian dogma or dismissed as heretical. Scholasticism played an important part in the integration of philosophical ideas into Christianity, remaining the predominant ethos for Christian education and theology until supplanted by humanist ideas in the Renaissance.